India's "Connect Central Asia" policy is consonant with its overall policy of deepening engagement in Eurasia, its policy of strengthening relations with China, with Pakistan, and building on its traditional relationship with Russia. India hopes that its membership in numerous regional forums including at the SCO, would bolster India's renewed linkages with the region.

ACT EAST POLICY OF INDIA

In 2014, the Modi Government upgraded India's "Look East Policy" and re-named it as the "Act East Policy". The "Look East Policy" was first initiated in 1992 by the then Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao.

The features (or elements) of India's "Act East Policy" are as follows[6]:

1. India's Act East Policy focusses on the extended neighbourhood in the Asia-Pacific region. The policy which was originally conceived as an economic initiative, has gained political, strategic and cultural dimensions including establishment of institutional mechanisms for dialogue and cooperation.

2. Act East Policy has placed emphasis on India-ASEAN cooperation in our domestic agenda on infrastructure, manufacturing, trade, skills, urban renewal, smart cities, Make in India and other initiatives.

3. The objective of ''Act East Policy" is to promote economic cooperation, cultural ties and develop strategic relationship with countries in the Asia-Pacific region through continuous engagement at bilateral, regional and multilateral levels.

4. The North East of India has been a priority in our Act East Policy. The policy provides an interface between North East India including the state of Arunachal Pradesh and the ASEAN region.

5. On the Civilizational front, Buddhist and Hindu links are being energized to develop new contacts and connectivity between people.

6. On Connectivity, special efforts are being made to develop a coherent strategy, particularly for linking ASEAN with North East India.

7. India's economic engagement with ASEAN has been stepped up. The ASEAN-India Agreement on Trade in Service and Investments has entered into force for India and seven ASEAN countries from 1 July 2015.

8. On strategic issues, India has increased convergence on security interests with key partners both in bilateral and multilateral format. Closer cooperation in combating terrorism, collaborating for peace and stability in the region and promotion of maritime security based on international norms and laws are being pursued.

[1]It includes world political climate, world public opinion and world organisations.

[2]India again re-established full diplomatic relations with South Africa in 1994 when the policy of racial discrimination was finally given up and democratic government under Nelson Mandela came into existence.

[3]A.S. Narang: *Indian Government and Politics*, Gitanjali, 2000 Edition, p. 602.